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Dear Hiring Manager,

I'm a Computer Science student and Presidential Scholarship recipient at Alfred University, applying for a Summer 2027 internship with your team. My background is unusual for a sophomore: I've founded a UNDP-funded fintech startup, shipped more than ten AI applications, and completed selective programs with AI4ALL, CodePath, Goldman Sachs, and McKinsey. What connects all of it is that I build products end to end — from understanding users and shaping a roadmap to writing the code that ships.

On the engineering side, I built seven AI applications in CodePath's Applied AI Engineering program using Claude, OpenAI APIs, RAG pipelines with vector search and embeddings, and agentic workflows — including human-in-the-loop systems with safety guardrails designed for high-stakes automated decisions. For a computer vision course, I deployed a real-time multi-person tracking pipeline (YOLOv8 + DeepSort) that achieved 80% detection accuracy with persistent identity tracking across full-length video. Most recently, as an AI4ALL Ignite Fellow, my seven-person team built a machine learning model predicting jet engine remaining useful life on NASA's Turbofan (CMAPSS) dataset — applying Random Forest and Logistic Regression to multi-sensor degradation data, auditing the dataset for bias, and cross-validating across engine types. That project taught me as much about responsible AI and explaining tradeoffs to non-technical audiences as it did about model selection.

I've also done client and product work outside the classroom. I built Vantage AI, an LLM-powered platform for a financial advisory firm, taking it from client conversations through system design to working software, and I shipped Workbox, a full-stack productivity application, and an open-source JavaScript data visualization library. At Headstarter AI, mentored by Y Combinator-backed founders who collectively raised \$50M+, I led go-to-market for a personal project that acquired 1,000+ waitlist users and generated \$1,000 in early revenue within weeks — my first real lesson in product-market fit.

The deepest lesson came from founding Kibenki, a fintech startup providing emergency liquidity to SME workers in Tanzania who are excluded from traditional credit. I raised 4,000,000 TZS in seed capital from the UNDP, secured venture-building support from Starthub Africa and the Funguo Program (UNDP, EU, UK Aid), and owned everything from product vision and user research to regulatory compliance with the Tanzania Startup Association. McKinsey's Forward Program and Goldman Sachs' Possibilities Series sharpened how I structure problems and communicate with executives — skills I now apply to every technical decision I make.

Beyond work, I worked with former BBC journalist Vicky Ntetema at Smota, the nonprofit she founded to support underserved families of children with albinism in Tanzania — including survivors of albinism-related violence such as killings and the amputation of body parts — contributing on the development, communications, and digital sides as the organization got off the ground. I also co-founded a technology literacy program that taught Python, design, and entrepreneurship to 50+ young people in Zanzibar, and helped five students from difficult backgrounds earn international scholarships. These experiences shaped how I approach problems: start with the people affected, then build.

I'd welcome the chance to bring this combination of engineering skill and product judgment to your team, whether in a product management, engineering, or AI-focused role. I'm happy to share project repositories, references, or anything else useful, and I look forward to speaking with you.

Warm regards,

William Frank Mahunda

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